



Strings

Director: Anders Rønnow Klarlund

©/Production Company: Bald Film

©/In co-production with:

Zentropa Entertainments ApS,

Sandrew Metronome Denmark, Mainstream,

Radar Film, Bob Film Sweden, Nordisk Film

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Rikskringkasting, Nordisk Film- och TV-Fond

International Sales: Trust Film Sales ApS

Producer: Niels Bald

Screenplay: Naja Marie Aidt

Story: Naja Marie Aidt, Anders Rønnow Klarlund

Directors of Cinematography: Kim Hattesen,

Jan Weincke

Visual Effects Supervisor: Daniel Silwerfeldt

Puppet Building Supervisor: Bernd Ogródnik

Chief Puppet Builder: Joakim Zachó Weylandt

Editor: Leif Axel Kjeldsen

Production Designer: Sven Wichmann

Composer: Jørgen Lauritsen

Voice Cast:

James McAvoy (*Prince Hal*)

Catherine McCormack (*Zita*)

Julian Glover (*Kahro*)

Derek Jacobi (*Nezo*)

Ian Hart (*Ghrak*)

Claire Skinner (*Jhinna*)

David Harewood (*Erito*)

Samantha Bond (*Eike*)

Michael Culkin (*Agra*)

Alexandra Knapp (*Daya*)

Oliver Golding (*Xath*)

Nigel Hoyle (*Lohsa*)

Andrew Kiernan (*Talino*)

Alex Jennings (*Utay*)

Malena Kristian (*women at marketplace*)

Hugo Myers, Catherine Kanter, Jonty Stephens,

Debbie Chazen (*voice artists*)

Piers Stubbs, Ruby Williams (*child voice artists*)

Denmark-Sweden-Norway-UK 2004©

92 mins

Digital

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SIGHT AND SOUND

No Strings Attached: Puppets on Film

Strings

Director's Statement

I was 30,000 feet above ground, when the idea for *Strings* began to take shape. The aircraft was moving along high above the clouds and on the small screen in front of me, a commercial taking place in Prague was playing. It had marionette puppets as actors and I was amazed at how much expression they could display. I began to wonder how the world would be if I was a marionette and I drew up a sketch of a marionette fleeing his enemy. The puppet was sitting in a treetop while tens of thousands of strings, were closing in on him. I immediately felt the idea was very strong. An idea of a universe inhabited by marionettes with strings reaching all the way up to the sky, to a place where we are all connected -and controlled.

I promised myself that if I won the European Fantasy Film Award for *Possessed*, my next project would be *Strings*. The plane touched down and a few days later I was accepting the award.

Out of that initial fascination with this unique universe emerged the themes suggested by puppets; existential themes touched on by both Goethe and Karen Blixen, themes of being connected and controlled. Then it came to me that Goethe had written Faust as a puppet play. I travelled to Prague and delved into the old tradition which evolved behind the Iron Curtain of telling political stories through puppet theatre when one wished to criticise the system.

In collaboration with writer Naja Marie Aidt a story began to unfold. An existential story, but one whose theme is very much of our time; for we live in a time when we are discovering day by day that we are our own worst enemies. A time where the image of the enemy is more clearly defined than ever before, but in which we are going to war against an invisible foe, pursuing a phantasm of evil – and where the only result is that we are constantly brought face to face with the enemy within ourselves.

We transferred this contemporary political reality to the fantastical world of puppetry and had the lead characters play out a political drama about the thirst for revenge on unseen enemies; about self-discovery and all those threads that connect us to our past and which so often control our lives. A fable about severing the threads connecting us to the misdeeds of the past in order to be connected to the present – and with everything that lives on this planet earth.

It's now four years since this idea came to me in the clouds 30,000 feet above the surface of the earth. Fortunately at the time I had no inkling of how demanding a task it was going to be to realise such a project.

Four years later, 4 million euros spent, and 200 dedicated film workers from all over Europe have worked for months and invested their hearts and souls in the project. Therefore it is with extreme pride that I present to you, the first fully integrated Marionette feature film *Strings*.

Anders Rønnow Klarlund

No Strings Attached: Puppets on Film

Television Puppets

Sat 1 Aug 12:15

Little Shop of Horrors (Director's Cut)

Sat 1 Aug 20:35; Sat 22 Aug 18:10;

Fri 28 Aug 20:45

Yonderland + Q&A with Jim Howick and

Laurence Rickard

Sun 2 Aug 14:30

The Muppets

Mon 3 Aug 14:30; Fri 7 Aug 20:30;

Thu 20 Aug 12:00; Sat 29 Aug 15:00

Eraserhead

Mon 3 Aug 18:30; Tue 11 Aug 20:35;

Thu 20 Aug 21:00; Tue 25 Aug 20:30

E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial

Mon 3 Aug 20:40; Wed 5 Aug 12:00; Wed 12 Aug

12:00; Tue 18 Aug 14:30; Sat 22 Aug 12:10;

Fri 28 Aug 12:00

The Double Life of Véronique

La double vie de Véronique

Tue 4 Aug 20:35; Sun 9 Aug 18:30;

Wed 19 Aug 18:20; Wed 26 Aug 20:55

The Dark Crystal

Wed 5 Aug 20:40; Sat 8 Aug 12:10;

Thu 13 Aug 12:00; Sun 23 Aug 10:00 BFI IMAX;

Mon 24 Aug 14:00

The Muppets Take Manhattan

Fri 7 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 12:10

Godzilla Gojira

Fri 7 Aug 21:00; Fri 21 Aug 20:45;

Wed 26 Aug 18:20

The Empire Strikes Back

Sat 8 Aug 17:40; Sat 15 Aug 10:30 BFI IMAX;

Tue 18 Aug 20:30; Fri 21 Aug 23:00 BFI IMAX;

Mon 31 Aug 10:30 BFI IMAX

Alice

Sat 8 Aug 20:45; Sun 16 Aug 18:30;

Mon 31 Aug 14:45

The Puppetoon Movie

Sun 9 Aug 12:20; Mon 31 Aug 12:10

Don't Hug Me I'm Scared + Q&A with creators

Becky Sloan and Joe Pelling

Mon 10 Aug 18:15

Muppets and Fraggles: A Celebration + Q&A with

co-creator and writer of *Fraggle Rock* Jocelyn

Stevenson

Tue 11 Aug 18:15

Team America: World Police

Wed 12 Aug 18:15; Sat 22 Aug 20:45

Annette

Wed 12 Aug 20:15; Sat 29 Aug 17:50

Strings

Sat 15 Aug 15:10; Sun 30 Aug 12:10

Child's Play

Sat 15 Aug 18:20; Wed 19 Aug 21:00

Magic

Sun 16 Aug 12:15; Thu 27 Aug 20:50

Being John Malkovich

Mon 17 Aug 20:40; Mon 31 Aug 18:30

The production

The creation of the world's first marionette puppet feature film was not unlike when the famous adventurer and polar scientist Robert Peary travelled to the North Pole – we had years of preparation, a long hard journey and no one to ask for help along the way. This had never been done before.

Before coming to a decision to make the film, we produced four pilots and extensive work designing a puppet that could move on film with credibility and be controlled with strings up to five metres long. The puppet prototype was made by combining old and new techniques, a puppet that at times took five puppeteers to control.

The marionettes were also made with materials designed to reflect their personal history and status. Prince Hal was made of gold, while soldiers were mass-produced from timber. The characters' faces were also important and simple metaphors were used to inform the viewer of the character's place in the world.

'Earth, wind, water and fire' were some of the key words during the shoot. The marionettes were subjected to all these elements during the 23 weeks of filming, a production where many of film history's oldest tricks were used to create the necessary illusions. This is not a film with 3D animated characters or using animated movements – everything is performed by hand using the best available craftsmanship.

It took 4 years, 115 specially designed marionette puppets, 22 of the top puppeteers from Europe and the USA, a crew of more than 150 Scandinavians and 10 kilometres of strings to make this film.

Production notes